



(L TO R) MOHAMMED FAIZAL, SATISH KAUSHIK, TANNISHTHA CHATTERJEE AND ABHAY DEOL IN *ROAD*, MOVIE



Aarekti Premier Golpo
Director Kaushik Ganguly
Movie within a movie about a transgender actor shot by a gay director. Melodramatic but touching.



OMKAR DAS MANIKPURI IN *PEEPLI LIVE*

Peepli Live
Director Anusha Rizvi
A comic take on farmers' suicides that mocks politics and news television. No one is spared.

Though *Aamir*, its producer, was sorely missed by the publicists, Rizvi handled the questions well, talking at length about how she had "stalked" the star via email in 2004. He thought it was a prank because her film was then called *The Falling* and he was working on *The Rising*. If in Rizvi's film the city came to *Peepli* and left only when the story was told, or sold, then in 50-year-old Dev Benegal's *Road, Movie*, the city travels with the desert. Shot in Rajasthan and Kutch in Gujarat over 60 days, the film starring actor-on-the-edge Abhay Deol and the female Irrfan Khan, Tannishtha Chatterjee, tracks the story of a simple young man, Vishnu, whose family wants him to sell hair oil, but who is more interested in a little adventure, delivering a truck with a travelling cinema. With clips from Buster Keaton and Amitabh Bachchan films from *Zanjeer* to *Deewar*, the journey sets the stage for several dream like sequences involving a circus, a group of women travelling miles for water, an encounter with a brutal police officer, and as is now expected from Deol, some extreme scenes.

RITUPARNO GHOSH AND INDRANEIL SENGUPTA IN *AAREKTI PREMIER GOLPO*

If he was tied to a bed and raped in *Ek Chaalis ki Last Local* and made to bathe in a tub in *Dev.D*, here he not only smokes ganja, has sex with Tannishtha's gypsy but also has a defecation scene in the middle of the desert. And he says, sitting in the lounge of the Berlinale Palast, where huge signed posters of stars, among them Shah Rukh Khan and Kajol, are mounted on the walls, "This is very tame. I'd like to go as far as I possibly can." He finds it harder to play "likeable than unlikeable characters" and he may well get a chance to challenge himself again in a new film he's ready to do, a road movie set in Spain, directed by Zoya Akhtar and starring Hrithik Roshan and Farhan Akhtar.

Berlinale did indeed dance with danger, whether it was Casey Affleck bludgeoning Jessica Alba after having lusty sex with her in Michael Winterbottom's *The Killer Inside Me* that had people gripping their seats in shock, or whether it was Mark Ruffalo going at it with his lesbian donor mother, Julianne Moore, in Lisa